



The Language of College

A Reading, Writing & Communication Toolkit

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The newest version is on the website: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/>

Contents

Understand the assignment

[Understanding a Writing Prompt](#)

Take part in class

[Writing a Discussion Post](#)

[Replying to Classmates](#)

Grammar for college writing

[Articles: A, An, The](#)

Instructor Companion

[Writing a Clear Assignment Prompt](#)

[Setting Expectations for Discussions and Journals](#)

[Assignment Prompt Builder](#)

Understand the assignment

UNDERSTAND THE ASSIGNMENT

Understanding a Writing Prompt

Use this page when your instructor gives you a writing assignment and you want to be sure what it asks you to do.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/assignments/writing-prompt.html>

What a prompt tells you

A **writing prompt** is the set of instructions for a writing assignment. Your grade depends on doing what the prompt asks, so read it slowly, at least two times, before you start to write.

Good writers at every level sometimes answer a different question than the one the prompt asked. A careful reading prevents that. As you read, look for the answers to five questions.

- 1 What do I do?** Find the task verb, such as explain, compare, or argue.
- 2 What do I write about?** Find the topic and any limits on the topic.
- 3 Who is my reader?** Some prompts name a reader. If the prompt does not, write for a reader who has not taken your class.
- 4 What are the requirements?** Find the length, the number of sources, and the format.
- 5 How do I finish?** Find the due date, the place to submit your work, and how it will be graded.

If the prompt does not answer one of these questions, ask your instructor. That is a normal and useful question.

KEY TERMS

Writing prompt: the instructions for a writing assignment.

Task verb: the verb that names the kind of thinking and writing you must do.

Rubric: a chart that shows how your work will be graded.

Example: reading a prompt closely

Here is a prompt from a first-year writing course. Six phrases are highlighted. Each number matches a note below the prompt.

A writing prompt with notes

Essay 2: A Change Worth Making

Think of **one problem at your workplace, in your neighborhood, or at this college**. **1** Write an essay that **argues for one specific change** **2** that would improve the situation. Your readers are **the people who could make that change**, **3** so explain the problem clearly and give reasons they would accept.

Support your argument with evidence from **at least two credible sources**. **4** Your essay should be **750–1,000 words in MLA format**. **5** Submit your essay in Blackboard by the due date listed there. **See the rubric** **6** for how this essay will be graded.

1 The topic, with a choice.

You choose the problem. The word **or** tells you to choose one of the three places, not all three.

2 The task.

The task verb is **argues**. To argue is to state your position and give reasons for it. Describing the problem is not enough. The words **one specific** set a limit: write about one change, and say exactly what it is.

3 The reader.

You are writing to people who have the power to make the change. Ask yourself what they already know and what reasons matter to them.

4 A requirement with a number.

At least two means two or more. One source is too few. **Credible** means that readers can trust the source.

5 Length and format.

Your essay needs between 750 and 1,000 words. MLA is a set of rules for how a paper looks and how it names its sources. The word **should** is a requirement here. See the language focus below.

6 How you will be graded.

The rubric shows what your instructor will look for. Read it before you write, not after.

TIP

Now answer the five questions for this prompt. If you can answer all five in your own words, you understand the assignment.

Language focus: required, allowed, or not allowed

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Commands

Prompts often start a sentence with a verb: **Write an essay. Support your argument. Submit your essay.** These sentences are commands. They have no subject because the subject is always you. In a prompt, a command is not rude. It is a requirement.

Small words that change the meaning

Words such as **must**, **should**, and **may** tell you how much choice you have.

Words that show what is required

Words in the prompt	What they mean	Example
must need to are required to	Required.	You must name every source you use.
should are expected to	Required in most prompts. In conversation, should gives advice. In a prompt, treat it as a rule.	Your essay should be 750–1,000 words.
may can are allowed to	Allowed. You choose.	You may write in first person (I, my).
are encouraged to consider	A good idea, but your choice.	Consider sharing your draft with a tutor.
may not must not do not	Not allowed.	Do not use outside sources.

WATCH FOR THIS

In a prompt, **may not** means “not allowed.” It does not mean “maybe not.”

Words that set limits

- **at least two sources:** two or more.
- **no more than 1,000 words:** 1,000 words or fewer.
- **750–1,000 words:** any number from 750 to 1,000.
- **one specific change:** exactly one, described clearly.

Sentence starters: asking about a prompt

Instructors expect questions about prompts. Ask early, and say what you already understand. Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

I want to check my understanding. The essay should _____. Is that correct?

TO ASK ABOUT THE PURPOSE

What skill should I practice in this assignment?

TO ASK WHAT A WORD MEANS

In the prompt, what does “_____” mean?

TO ASK ABOUT A LIMIT

Does the word count include _____?

TO ASK ABOUT YOUR TOPIC

May I write about _____ for this assignment?

TO ASK WHAT IS ALLOWED

Are we allowed to use _____ for this assignment?

Practice

Read this prompt for a discussion post. Then answer the questions.

Read the assigned article about working from home. In one paragraph of 150–200 words, summarize the author’s main argument. Then, in a second paragraph, explain whether you agree with the author. Use one example from your own experience. You may write in first person (I, my). Do not use outside sources.

1. What are the two task verbs?

2. How many paragraphs must you write?
3. Is it acceptable to write “I agree because my job changed last year”?
4. You find a helpful website about working from home. Can you quote it in your post?
5. What does the prompt not tell you?

Suggested answers

1. Summarize and explain.

First you report the author’s main argument in fewer words. Then you give your own position and your reasons.

2. Two.

The prompt says “one paragraph” and then “a second paragraph.”

3. Yes.

“You may write in first person” means it is allowed. The prompt also asks for an example from your own experience.

4. No.

“Do not use outside sources” is a command. The only source you can use is the assigned article.

5. The length of the second paragraph, the due date, and how the post is graded.

These are good questions to ask. You could write: “Does the 150–200 word limit apply to the second paragraph too?”

Next step

Try this with a prompt from one of your classes

1. Highlight the task verb.
2. Underline every number and every word that sets a limit.
3. Circle any word you do not know. Look it up, or ask your instructor.

4. Write the task in one sentence: “In this assignment, I will _____ about _____ for _____.”

Related pages

Task verbs: analyze, compare, evaluate Coming soon

What each common task verb asks you to do.

Reading a rubric Coming soon

How to use a rubric before, during, and after you write.

FOR INSTRUCTORS [Writing a clear assignment prompt](#)

The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

Take part in class

TAKE PART IN CLASS

Writing a Discussion Post

Use this page when your class has an online discussion and you need to write your first post.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/participate/discussion-post.html>

What a discussion post is

Many college courses have an online **discussion board**. Your instructor asks a question. Each student writes an answer, called a **first post**, and the whole class can read it. Then students reply to each other.

This page is about the first post. A discussion is a conversation in writing. It is more careful than a text message and less formal than an essay.

Where a discussion post fits

	Text message	Discussion post	Essay
Who reads it	A friend	Your classmates and your instructor	Your instructor, in most classes
Sentences	Short pieces and abbreviations	Complete sentences	Complete sentences in organized paragraphs
Using “I”	Yes	Yes, in most classes	It depends on the assignment
Your opinion	Yes	Yes, with a reason	Yes, with reasons and evidence

What instructors expect

Instructors do not always write these expectations down. In most U.S. college classes, they apply to every student.

- **Answer every part of the question.** Many discussion questions have two parts, such as “which one, and why?”
- **Give your own opinion, and give a reason for it.** Repeating the reading is not enough.
- **Connect your answer to the course.** Use an idea from the reading or the lesson.
- **Remember who can read your post.** Your whole class can read it. Share only what you are comfortable sharing with classmates.
- **Post early when you can.** Classmates need time to read your post and reply.

KEY TERMS

Discussion board: the place in an online course where students post and reply.

First post: your own answer to the instructor’s question. It is also called an initial post.

Reply: a response to a classmate’s post.

Netiquette: polite and respectful behavior in online communication.

Four parts of a strong first post

1 Answer. Answer the question in your first sentence. Use some of the words from the question.

2 Reason. Say why. One clear reason is better than three weak ones.

3 Support. Add an idea from the reading, an example from your experience, or both.

4 Question. End with a question for your classmates.

WHY END WITH A QUESTION?

A question is an invitation. Classmates who are looking for a post to reply to will find yours easy to answer, and you will get more interesting replies. Do this unless your prompt asks for something different.

Example: a first post

The instructor asked this question: “**This week’s reading describes three time-management strategies. Which strategy would be most useful for you, and why? Write 100–150 words.**”

Here is one student’s post. Each number matches a note below the post.

A first post with notes

The most useful strategy for me is breaking a large task into small steps. ① I work full time, so I rarely have three free hours to study. ② The reading explains that a small step is easier to start than a large task, ③ and I think this is true. For example, last week I had to read a long chapter for my biology class. ④ I divided the chapter into four sections and read one section each night after work. I finished one day early. I am less sure about the weekly schedule, because my work hours change every week. ⑤ Does anyone else have a schedule that changes? How do you plan your study time? ⑥

① **The answer.**

The first sentence answers “which strategy.” It repeats the words **most useful** and **strategy** from the question, so readers know at once what the post is about.

② **The reason.**

This sentence answers “why.” It is specific to the writer’s own life.

③ **Support from the reading.**

The writer names the source (**The reading explains that**) and gives the idea in different words.

④ **Support from experience.**

For example tells readers that a real case is coming. The details (four sections, one each night) make it believable.

⑤ **A second thought.**

This part is optional. It shows that the writer considered another strategy, and it prepares the question.

6 The question.

The question comes from the post, and a classmate can answer it from experience. It cannot be answered with only “yes” or “no.”

Language focus: asking a question

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Word order in questions

In most English questions, a helping verb such as do, does, did, has, or would comes before the subject.

How a question is built

Question word	Helping verb	Subject	Main verb and the rest
How	do	you	plan your study time?
What	would	you	do in this situation?
Why	does	this strategy	work for you?
(none)	Has	anyone else	had this experience?

WATCH FOR THIS

After do, does, or did, the main verb has no ending. Write **Why does this strategy work?**
Do not write “Why does this strategy works?”

Closed and open questions

A **closed question** can be answered in one word. An **open question** needs an explanation. Open questions get better replies.

- Closed: **Do you agree?**
- Open: **What is one reason someone might disagree?**

Open questions often begin with how, why, or what.

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO ANSWER THE QUESTION

The most _____ for me is _____.

I think _____ because _____.

TO USE THE READING

The reading explains that _____.

According to the article, _____.

TO GIVE AN EXAMPLE

For example, _____.

In my experience, _____.

TO END WITH A QUESTION

Has anyone else had this experience with _____?

How would you handle _____?

What is one reason someone might disagree with _____?

Practice

1. A student posts: **"I think the weekly schedule is the best strategy. Do you agree?"** Which two of the four parts are missing?
2. Which closing question will get the most useful replies?
 - A. Do you agree?
 - B. Thoughts?
 - C. What do you do when two assignments are due on the same day?
3. Correct this question: **"Why this strategy works for you?"**

4. Correct this question: **“Anyone has tried this strategy?”**

Suggested answers

1. The reason and the support.

The post gives an answer and a question. It does not say why, and it has no example or idea from the reading.

2. C.

A classmate can answer it from experience, and the answer needs more than one word. A is a closed question. B is not a complete question, so readers do not know what you are asking.

3. Why does this strategy work for you?

The helping verb does comes before the subject. After does, the main verb has no ending: work.

4. Has anyone tried this strategy?

The helping verb has moves to the front of the question.

Next step

Check your post before you submit it

1. Did I answer every part of the question?
2. Did I give a reason?
3. Did I add an example or an idea from the reading?
4. Did I end with an open question?
5. Is my post the right length? Check the word count in the prompt.

Related pages

[Understanding a writing prompt](#)

How to find the task, the requirements, and the limits in any prompt, including a discussion question.

[Replying to classmates](#)

How to agree, add an idea, and disagree politely.

Writing a journal or reflection

Coming soon

How to write about your own learning.

FOR INSTRUCTORS

[Setting expectations for discussions and journals](#)

The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

Replying to Classmates

Use this page when you need to reply to a classmate's post in an online discussion.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/participate/replying.html>

What a good reply does

A **reply** is your response to a classmate's post. A good reply adds something to the conversation. "I agree" or "Good post" is friendly, but it gives your classmate nothing to think about, and most instructors do not count it.

There are four useful kinds of reply. One reply can do more than one of them.

- 1 Answer.** If your classmate asked a question, answer it. This is the easiest way to start.
- 2 Agree and add.** Say what you agree with, then add something new: an example, a reason, or an idea from the reading.
- 3 Disagree politely.** Give a different view, and give your reason.
- 4 Ask.** Ask about something you want to understand better.

What instructors expect

Instructors do not always write these expectations down. In most U.S. college classes, they apply to every student.

- **Use your classmate's name.** It shows who you are talking to, and it is polite.
- **Show that you read the post.** Name the idea you are responding to.
- **You may disagree.** Disagreement is a normal part of a college discussion. It is welcome when you give a reason.
- **Write about the idea, not the person.**

- **Check the prompt.** It tells you how many replies to write and how long each one should be.

A KIND CHOICE

If you can choose, reply to a post that has no replies yet. Every student hopes that someone will answer.

KEY TERMS

Reply: a response to a classmate's post.

Thread: one post and all the replies to it.

Tone: the feeling your words give the reader, such as friendly, angry, or respectful.

Example: a reply

A classmate named Daniela wrote that breaking a large task into small steps works for her, but a weekly schedule does not, because her work hours change. She ended her post with a question: **“Does anyone else have a schedule that changes? How do you plan your study time?”**

Here is one reply. Each number matches a note below it.

A reply with notes

Daniela, **1** my schedule changes every week too, so I understand the problem. **2** I like your idea of reading one section each night. What works for me is planning on Sunday night, after my manager posts the schedule. I look for three short blocks of 30 minutes and put them in my phone calendar. **3** I see the weekly schedule a little differently, though. I think it can still work if you make a new one each week. **4** Have you tried studying during your breaks at work? **5**

1 The name.

The reply begins with the classmate's name.

2 The connection.

This sentence shows that the writer read the post and understood it.

3 The answer.

Daniela asked how other students plan their study time. The writer answers with exact details: when, how many, how long.

4 A polite disagreement.

The writer has a different view of the weekly schedule. The words **a little differently** and **I think** make the tone friendly. The second sentence gives the reason.

5 A question back.

The question keeps the conversation going. This part is optional.

Language focus: disagreeing politely

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Softening words

In English, a very direct disagreement can sound rude, even when the writer does not mean it that way. Writers add small **softening words** to keep a friendly tone.

The same opinion, with a different tone

Too direct	Polite and clear
You are wrong.	I see this differently.
That is not true.	I am not sure that is always true.
This strategy does not work.	This strategy might not work for everyone.
Your post is confusing.	I did not understand your second point. Could you explain it?

Common softening words: **I think, in my experience, might, may, could, sometimes, not always, a little.**

A pattern you can use

Say what you agree with or understand. Then give your different view and your reason.

- I agree that small steps help, but I think a schedule is also important because it protects your study time.
- I understand your point about cost. In my experience, though, the free tools work well.

WATCH FOR THIS

Softening changes your tone. It does not change your opinion. A reply with too many softening words can hide what you think, so state your view and give your reason.

Sentence starters

Fill in each blank with your own words.

TO ANSWER A CLASSMATE'S QUESTION

You asked about _____. What works for me is _____.

TO AGREE AND ADD

I agree that _____, and I would add _____.

I had a similar experience when _____.

TO DISAGREE POLITELY

I see this differently because _____.

I understand your point about _____, but _____.

TO ASK

Could you say more about _____?

What did you mean by _____?

Practice

1. The prompt says a reply "must add something." Which reply does?
 - A. Great post! I agree with everything you said.

- B. I agree that small steps help. I use the same idea for math homework: I do five problems, and then I take a break.
 - C. Nice job.
2. A classmate's post ends with this question: **"How do you stay focused when you study at home?"** What is the easiest way to begin your reply?
 3. Make this sentence polite and clear: **"You are wrong about the weekly schedule."**
 4. Which sentence is about the idea, not the person?
 - A. You did not read the article carefully.
 - B. I think the article says something different in the second paragraph.

Suggested answers

1. **B.**

It says what the writer agrees with and adds a new example. A and C are friendly, but they add nothing.

2. **Answer the question.**

For example: "You asked how to stay focused at home. What works for me is putting my phone in another room."

3. **One possible answer: "I see the weekly schedule differently. I think it helps because it shows me when I am free."**

The new sentence talks about the schedule, not the classmate, and it gives a reason. Other answers are possible.

4. **B.**

Sentence A judges the classmate. Sentence B talks about the article and gives the classmate something to check.

Next step

Check your reply before you submit it

1. Did I use my classmate's name?

2. Did I show which idea I am responding to?
3. Did I add something: an answer, an example, a reason, or a different view?
4. If I disagreed, did I give a reason and write about the idea?
5. Is my reply the right length? Check the prompt.

Related pages

[Writing a discussion post](#)

How to write the first post, including a closing question.

Interacting in class: common expectations

Coming soon

What instructors and classmates usually expect in a U.S. college class.

FOR INSTRUCTORS

[Setting expectations for discussions and journals](#)

The Instructor Companion page that pairs with this one.

Grammar for college writing

GRAMMAR FOR COLLEGE WRITING

Articles: A, An, The

Use this page when you are not sure whether a noun needs a, an, the, or no article.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/grammar/articles.html>

What articles do

English has three **articles**: **a**, **an**, and **the**. An article comes before a noun. It tells your reader whether you mean one specific thing or any one of many.

- **I read an article about sleep.** The reader does not know which article. It is one of many.
- **I read the article about sleep.** The reader knows which article. Maybe the instructor assigned it.

Many languages have no articles, so this part of English takes practice. A missing article rarely stops a reader from understanding you. Still, articles appear in almost every sentence, so a small improvement shows everywhere in your writing.

KEY TERMS

Noun: a word for a person, place, thing, or idea.

Countable noun: a noun you can count. It has a plural form: one essay, two essays.

Uncountable noun: a noun you cannot count. It has no plural form: research, information.

Three questions for every noun

When you are not sure, ask these questions in order. Stop at the first “yes.”

1 Does my reader know exactly which one I mean? If yes, use **the**.

2 Is the noun singular and countable? If yes, use **a** or **an**.

- 3 Is the noun plural or uncountable, and am I speaking in general? If yes, use no article.

When does my reader know which one?

- You already mentioned it. I wrote a draft. The draft was too short.
- Your sentence identifies it. the article that we read this week, the first paragraph
- There is only one. the author of an article, the instructor of your class, the sun

A or an?

Listen to the first sound of the next word. The spelling does not decide.

- Use **a** before a consonant sound: a draft, a university, a one-page summary.
- Use **an** before a vowel sound: an essay, an hour, an MLA citation.

Example: articles in a paragraph

This paragraph comes from a student's summary. Each number matches a note below it.

A paragraph with notes

I read an article 1 about sleep for my psychology class. The article 2 explains that college students need at least seven hours of sleep. Research 3 shows that students 4 who sleep less have more trouble remembering information. The author 5 gives an example from a study at a large university. 6 In the study, 7 students who slept longer earned higher grades.

1 First mention.

The reader does not know which article yet. The noun is singular and countable, so it needs a or an. Article begins with a vowel sound, so the writer uses an.

2 Second mention.

Now the reader knows which article, so the writer uses the.

3 **An uncountable noun, in general.**

Research is uncountable. The writer means research in general, so there is no article. **Information**, later in the same sentence, works the same way.

4 **A plural noun, in general.**

The writer means students in general, not one specific group, so there is no article.

5 **Only one.**

The article has one author, so the reader knows which person the writer means.

6 **Two first mentions.**

The reader does not know which study or which university. **University** begins with a “y” sound, so the writer uses **a**, not **an**.

7 **Second mention.**

The study was introduced in the sentence before, so now it is **the study**.

Three common problems

WATCH FOR THESE

1. Uncountable nouns in college writing

These nouns are common in college, and all of them are uncountable in English: **research, evidence, information, advice, feedback, homework, equipment, software**. Do not use a or an with them, and do not add -s.

Uncountable nouns

Not this	Write this
I did a research.	I did research. / I read a study.
The essay needs more evidences.	The essay needs more evidence.
She gave me an advice.	She gave me some advice. / She gave me a piece of advice.

Not this**Write this**

I found many informations.

I found a lot of information.

I finished my homeworks.

I finished my homework. / I finished my assignments.

2. A singular countable noun with nothing before it

A singular countable noun cannot stand alone. It needs an article or another small word such as my, this, or one. Use only one of them.

Singular countable nouns

Not this**Write this**

I wrote essay about my job.

I wrote an essay about my job.

The my essay is finished.

My essay is finished.

3. The in general statements

When you speak about a whole group in general, use a plural noun with no article.

- General: **Students need feedback.** This means students everywhere.
- Specific: **The students in my group need feedback.** This means one group that the reader can identify.

Phrases you will use often

You can learn these phrases as whole pieces. The article is already correct.

TO WRITE ABOUT A READING

According to the author, _____.

The main idea of the article is _____.

In the first paragraph, _____.

TO GIVE SUPPORT

This is an example of _____.

A study by _____ shows that _____.

TO EXPLAIN YOUR OWN WRITING

The purpose of this essay is to _____.

As a result, _____.

Practice

Choose **a**, **an**, **the**, or no article for each blank.

1. I wrote _____ essay about my first job.
2. _____ essay that I wrote last week needs more support.
3. My instructor gave me _____ feedback on my draft.
4. She said that I need _____ stronger thesis.
5. I need to find _____ information about wages.
6. It took me _____ hour to revise one paragraph.
7. _____ students often work while they attend college.

Then correct this sentence: “**I did a research for my homeworks.**”

Suggested answers

1. an

First mention, singular and countable. Essay begins with a vowel sound.

2. The

The words that I wrote last week identify which essay.

3. No article

Feedback is uncountable. Some feedback is also correct.

4. a

Singular and countable, and the reader does not know which thesis yet. Stronger begins with a consonant sound.

5. No article

Information is uncountable. Some information is also correct.

6. an

The h in hour is silent, so the word begins with a vowel sound.

7. No article

The sentence is about students in general. The first word is Students, with a capital letter.

Corrected sentence: I did research for my homework.

Both nouns are uncountable, so they take no a and no -s.

Next step

Try this with your own writing

1. Choose one paragraph from a draft.
2. Circle every noun.
3. Ask the three questions for each noun.
4. Check the list of uncountable nouns on this page.

More practice

The Purdue Online Writing Lab (OWL) is a writing site from Purdue University. Many college classes use it.

Purdue OWL: article exercises (https://owl.purdue.edu/owl_exercises/grammar_exercises/articles/)

Three exercises with answer pages.

Purdue OWL: How to Use Articles

(https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/grammar/using_articles.html)

A longer explanation, with rules for names of places.

Related pages

Subject-verb agreement Coming soon

How to make the verb match its subject.

Building a paragraph Coming soon

How to organize one main idea with support.

Instructor Companion

For faculty and staff. Students are welcome to read it too.

INSTRUCTOR COMPANION

Writing a Clear Assignment Prompt

Use this page when you are writing or revising the instructions for a writing assignment.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/assignment-prompts.html>

What students experience

A prompt is a reading task before it is a writing task. Students who read English as an additional language often read a prompt closely and take its wording literally. That works well when the prompt states its expectations. It works against them when the expectations are implied.

Five features of a prompt cause most of the difficulty:

- **The task is hard to find.** It sits inside background information or a series of questions, and the student cannot tell which questions must be answered.
- **Requirements sound optional.** “You might want to include a few sources” reads as a suggestion.
- **Idioms and cultural references carry the meaning.** “Dig into something that bugs you” depends on phrases a dictionary will not explain.
- **Key terms have no definition.** “Analyze,” “respond critically,” and “polished” mean different things in different courses.
- **The grading criteria are unstated.** Students cannot tell how much weight grammar carries next to ideas and organization.

None of these is a question of ability, and none is limited to multilingual learners. The CCCC statement on multilingual writers puts the principle in one sentence: “Instructors should provide clearly written assignments so that expectations are not left tacit.”

The evidence for stating expectations openly reaches beyond language. In a study at seven minority-serving institutions, two of them community colleges, faculty revised two take-home assignments to state the purpose, the task, and the criteria. Of the 1,800 students invited, 1,174 completed an end-of-term survey. Students who experienced more transparency reported greater academic confidence,

a stronger sense of belonging, and greater mastery of the skills employers value. The benefits were larger for first-generation, low-income, and underrepresented students (Winkelmes et al., 2016). The study did not examine multilingual learners as a separate group.

Six practices

1

State the purpose

In one or two sentences, say what skill the assignment builds and where students will use it again. Purpose helps students decide what matters most in their response.

2

Put the task first and name it with one verb

Lead with the sentence that says what to produce. Then define the task verb as you use it: “In this course, *analyze* means to explain how the parts of the text work together.”

3

Separate what is required from what is optional

Use *must* for requirements. Put suggestions under their own heading. Students are taught that *should* and *may* signal different levels of obligation, so use them consistently.

4

Put the requirements in a list

List length, sources, format, and submission steps as separate items, each with a number where one applies. Give length in words. A page count changes with font and spacing.

5

Explain or remove idioms and cultural references

Replace idioms with literal wording. Offer topic choices that do not depend on cultural or historical knowledge the course has not taught, as the CCCC statement recommends.

6

Say how the work will be evaluated, including language

Share the rubric with the prompt. State how much sentence-level accuracy counts next to ideas, evidence, and organization. State the AI level for the assignment, using the label from OCTC's [AI Label Maker](https://octc-id.github.io/AI-literacy-playbook/ai-label/) (<https://octc-id.github.io/AI-literacy-playbook/ai-label/>). Then say whether a dictionary, a translation tool, and a grammar checker are allowed, because an AI level does not answer that.

Before and after

Both versions describe the same assignment. The second is the one students see on the paired student page.

BEFORE

For this next paper I'd like you to dig into something that bugs you. We've all been there: something at work or around town that just doesn't work the way it should. What's going on? Why does it matter? Who's affected? What could be done about it?

You'll probably want to bring in a couple of sources to back yourself up, and it should run about three to four pages. Make sure it's polished!

AFTER**Purpose**

This essay gives you practice building an argument for a specific reader. You will use this skill in other courses and at work.

Task

Write an essay that argues for one specific change that would improve a problem at your workplace, in your neighborhood, or at this college. In this course, *argue* means to state a

position and support it with reasons and evidence.

Reader

Write for the people who could make the change.

Requirements

- 750–1,000 words
- Evidence from at least two credible sources
- MLA format
- Submitted in Blackboard by the due date listed there

Optional

You may write in first person (I, my).

Grading

See the rubric attached to this assignment.

What changed

- **Four idioms are gone:** “dig into,” “bugs you,” “we’ve all been there,” and “back yourself up.”
- **Four questions became one task.** A student no longer has to guess whether each question needs its own answer.
- **“Probably want to” and “a couple” became “at least two.”** The requirement is now a requirement, with a number.
- **Pages became words.**
- **“Polished” became a rubric.**
- **The reader is named.** The first version never says who the essay is for.

Wording you can copy

Replace the text in brackets.

Purpose. This assignment gives you practice with [skill]. You will use this skill when you [situation].

Task. Write a [type of text] that [task verb] [topic]. In this course, “[task verb]” means [definition].

Requirements. Your [type of text] must: [list, one item per line].

Optional. You may also [choice].

Language. Most of your grade is for [priorities, such as your argument and evidence]. Grammar and word choice count for [amount, or “only where they make your meaning unclear”].

Tools. AI level: [No AI / AI-supported / AI-integrated]. [If AI-supported: You may use AI for (uses). You may not use AI to (limit).] [If AI-integrated: With AI, you will (steps). On your own, you must (your part). To show how you used AI, turn in (evidence).] You [may / may not] use [a dictionary, a translation tool, a grammar checker] to [purpose]. If you are not sure whether a tool is allowed, ask me before you use it.

Questions. If any part of this prompt is unclear, ask me. Questions about a prompt are welcome.

Check before you post

These are the five questions the student page teaches. A student should be able to answer each one from the prompt alone.

1. What do I do? (One task, named with a defined verb.)
2. What do I write about? (The topic and its limits.)
3. Who is my reader?
4. What are the requirements? (Each one stated as a requirement, with a number.)
5. How do I finish? (Where to find the due date, where to submit, and how the work is graded.)

For a stronger check, ask a colleague outside your discipline to read the prompt and tell you what it asks for.

Link for students

The paired student page teaches the five questions, the difference between *must*, *should*, and *may*, and ways to ask about a prompt. You can add this line to an assignment in Blackboard:

Before you start, read [Understanding a Writing Prompt](#). It shows you how to find the task, the requirements, and the limits in any prompt.

Tool

The [Assignment prompt builder](#) turns these practices into a fill-in form, and it includes a Copilot prompt for checking a prompt you already have.

Sources

- Conference on College Composition and Communication. (2020). [CCCC statement on second language writing and multilingual writers](https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting) (https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting). See “Writing Assignment Design” and “Assessment.”
- Winkelmes, M., Bernacki, M., Butler, J., Zochowski, M., Golanics, J., & Weavil, K. H. (2016). A teaching intervention that increases underserved college students’ success. *Peer Review*, 18(1/2), 31–36. A summary handout with example assignments: [Transparent Instruction and Its Impact on Learning \(PDF\)](https://ts3.nashonline.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Winkelmes-TILT-Handout-accessible.pdf) (https://ts3.nashonline.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Winkelmes-TILT-Handout-accessible.pdf). More on the framework: [Transparency in Learning and Teaching \(TILT Higher Ed\)](https://tilthighered.com/) (https://tilthighered.com/).

Setting Expectations for Discussions and Journals

Use this page when you assign discussion posts, journals, or reflections.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/discussions-journals.html>

What students experience

Discussions and journals depend on unwritten rules more than any other assignment type. An instructor who has read thousands of posts knows what a good one looks like, so a prompt such as “post your thoughts and respond to two classmates” feels complete. To a student, it leaves most of the assignment undefined.

This affects every student. Some skim the instructions and miss a detail that is there. Others read every word and still cannot find the expectation, because it was never written down. Multilingual learners are often in the second group, and they may also be working from classroom conventions learned in a different educational system.

These are the questions students most often cannot answer from the prompt:

DISCUSSIONS

- How formal should my writing be?
- May I write “I”?
- Do I need sources?
- What counts as a reply?
- May I disagree with a classmate? With the reading? With the instructor?
- Is my grammar graded?

JOURNALS AND REFLECTIONS

- Who will read this?
- How personal should it be?
- May I say that something in the course is not working for me?
- Is it safe to admit that I did not understand?
- Is my grammar graded?

Expectations about disagreement, self-disclosure, and how to address an instructor differ between educational systems. The CCCC statement asks instructors to check their assignments for unstated cultural assumptions, and it notes that topics drawing on personal experience can be sensitive for some students. The practical response is the same in every case: state the expectation.

Eight practices

1

Say what the activity is for

One sentence is enough. “This discussion gives you practice explaining an idea from the reading to other people.”

2

Say who will read it

Students write differently for the whole class than for one instructor. For a journal, say plainly whether anyone but you will see it.

3

Describe the style you expect

State whether you want complete sentences, whether “I” is acceptable, and whether sources are needed. “Be professional” and “use netiquette” do not answer these questions.

4

Define a reply

Give a length and say what a reply must do: answer a classmate’s question, add an example, or explain a different view with a reason. Say that “I agree” alone does not count.

5

Say that disagreement is welcome, and show how

A student who was taught not to contradict a classmate or an instructor may need explicit permission. Give them wording: “I see this differently because ...”

6

Say how language is graded

Decide how much sentence-level accuracy counts in low-stakes writing, and state it either way. A student who does not know may assume that every error costs points, and write less.

7

Show an annotated model

One model post with notes shows length, style, and depth faster than a paragraph of description. The transparency framework treats annotated examples as part of the criteria (Winkelmes et al., 2016).

8

Offer an alternative to personal topics

When a prompt asks about family, background, or personal difficulty, give a second option that does not, as the CCCC statement recommends.

A PRACTICE TO TRY

Ask students to end each first post with an open question for classmates. It gives every student who must “reply to two classmates” a place to start. This is practitioner advice. We did not find a study that tests it directly.

Before and after

Both versions describe the same discussion. The second matches the example on the paired student page.

BEFORE**AFTER**

Post your thoughts on this week's reading and respond to two classmates. Be thoughtful, and remember your netiquette!

Purpose

This discussion gives you practice explaining an idea from the reading to other people.

First post

Answer this question: Which time-management strategy from the reading would be most useful for you, and why? Write 100–150 words. Give one reason and one example. End with a question for your classmates.

Replies

Reply to two classmates. Each reply must be at least 50 words. A reply must add something: answer your classmate's question, give an example, or explain a different view with a reason.

Style

Write in complete sentences. You may use "I." You do not need outside sources.

Disagreement

You may disagree with a classmate or with the reading. Give a reason, and write about the idea, not the person.

Grading

See the rubric. Grammar and spelling are not graded in discussions unless they make your meaning unclear.

Due dates

See Blackboard for the first-post and reply due dates.

What changed

- “Your thoughts” became one question with two parts.
- “Thoughtful” became a length, a reason, and an example.
- “Respond” became a definition of a reply.
- “Netiquette” became two concrete expectations: a style, and a way to disagree.
- The grading of language is stated. The line shown is one possible policy. Use your own.

Wording you can copy

Replace the text in brackets.

For journals and reflections

Reader. [Only I will read your journal. / Your journal is shared with your group.]

What to share. You choose what to share. You never have to write about private matters. If a prompt asks about personal experience and you prefer not to answer, you may write about [alternative topic].

Honesty. You may write about what is difficult or not working for you in this course. Honest answers will not lower your grade.

Language. I read your journal for your ideas. [Grammar and spelling are not graded. / Grammar and spelling count for (amount).]

For discussions, in place of “netiquette”

In our discussions:

- Begin a reply with your classmate’s name.

- Write in complete sentences. Do not write in all capital letters.
- You may disagree. Give a reason, and write about the idea, not the person.
- Jokes and sarcasm are easy to misread in writing. Use them with care.
- If a post confuses or upsets you, ask the writer a question before you respond, or contact me.

Links for students

Two student pages pair with this one. The first teaches the four parts of a first post and how to form an open question. The second teaches four kinds of reply and how to disagree politely. You can add these lines to a discussion in Blackboard:

Before you post, read [Writing a Discussion Post](#). It shows you what a strong first post includes.

Before you reply, read [Replying to Classmates](#). It shows you how to add to a conversation and how to disagree politely.

To draft or check a prompt of your own, use the [Assignment prompt builder](#).

Sources

- Conference on College Composition and Communication. (2020). [CCCC statement on second language writing and multilingual writers](https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting) (<https://cccc.ncte.org/cccc/resources/positions/secondlangwriting>). See “Writing Assignment Design” and Part Four, “Guidelines for Teacher Preparation.”
- Winkelmess, M., Bernacki, M., Butler, J., Zochowski, M., Golanics, J., & Weavil, K. H. (2016). A teaching intervention that increases underserved college students' success. *Peer Review*, 18(1/2), 31–36.

Assignment Prompt Builder

Use this page when you want to draft a new assignment prompt or check one you already have.

Online: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/prompt-builder.html>

Build a prompt

Fill in what you know, then choose **Build prompt**. The tool assembles your answers under clear headings and lists anything a student could not tell from the prompt. Copy the result into Blackboard and edit it there.

The fill-in builder works on the website. Open this page online to use it: <https://octc-id.github.io/language-of-college/instructors/prompt-builder.html>

Check a prompt with Copilot

If you already have a prompt, Microsoft Copilot can read it the way a careful student would and show you what is missing. Copilot is part of the college's Microsoft 365 package. Copy the text below into Copilot, then paste your own prompt at the end.

You are helping a college instructor revise an assignment prompt so that every student can understand it, including students who read English as an additional language. Do not change what the assignment asks students to do. Do not make the assignment easier.

Step 1. List what a student could not tell from this prompt. Check each of these:

- the task and its main verb
- the topic and its limits
- the intended reader
- each requirement, and its number
- what is optional
- how the work is graded, including how much grammar counts

- the AI level (No AI, AI-supported, or AI-integrated)
- if the level is AI-supported, exactly which uses are allowed and which are not
- if the level is AI-integrated, the tool, the steps for using AI, what students must do themselves, and what they turn in to show how they used AI
- which language tools are allowed (dictionary, translation tool, grammar checker)
- where to submit the work and where to find the due date

Step 2. List every idiom, cultural reference, and undefined academic term in the prompt. Suggest plain wording for each one.

Step 3. List any requirement that is worded as a suggestion, such as "you might want to."

Step 4. Rewrite the prompt under these headings: Purpose, Task, Reader, Requirements, Optional, Grading, Tools. Use short sentences and common words. Use "must" for requirements. Where information is missing, write [INSTRUCTOR: add ...]. Do not invent requirements, numbers, or policies.

Here is my prompt:

[paste your prompt here]

Or start from scratch with Copilot

If you do not have a prompt yet and prefer a conversation to a form, use this version. Copilot asks you one question at a time and writes the prompt when you say "ready." Allow five to ten minutes.

You are helping a college instructor write a clear assignment prompt that every student can understand, including students who read English as an additional language.

Interview me one question at a time. Wait for my answer before you ask the next question. Do not draft anything until I say "ready."

Ask about each of these, in this order:

1. the skill this assignment builds, and where students will use it again

2. the type of text and the task, named with one verb
3. what that verb means in my course
4. the topic and its limits
5. the intended reader
6. each requirement, with a number (length in words, number of sources, format)
7. what is optional
8. what counts most in the grade, and how much grammar and word choice count
9. the AI level (No AI, AI-supported, or AI-integrated). If I answer AI-supported, ask which uses are allowed (for example, brainstorming or feedback on a draft) and which are not. If I answer AI-integrated, ask which tool students use, what they do with AI, what they must do themselves, and what they turn in to show how they used AI
10. which language tools are allowed (dictionary, translation tool, grammar checker)
11. where students submit the work and find the due date

If my answer is vague, ask one follow-up question. If I say "skip," move on.

When I say "ready," write the prompt under these headings: Purpose, Task, Reader, Requirements, Optional, Grading, Tools, Submitting. Use short sentences and common words. Do not use idioms. Use "must" for requirements. For anything I skipped, write [INSTRUCTOR: add ...]. Do not invent requirements, numbers, or college policies.

Start with question 1.

Before you use either prompt

- **Sign in to Copilot with your college account.** For the college's approach to AI in courses, see the [AI Literacy Faculty Playbook](https://octc-id.github.io/AI-literacy-playbook/) (<https://octc-id.github.io/AI-literacy-playbook/>).
- **Share only the assignment.** Leave out student names and student work.
- **Read the result against your original.** Copilot can change your meaning while it simplifies your wording. The bracketed notes mark places where it needed information from you.
- **You make the decisions.** The tool finds gaps. What the assignment requires is up to you.

Related pages

[Writing a clear assignment prompt](#)

The six practices behind this tool, with a before-and-after example.

[Setting expectations for discussions and journals](#)

What to add when the assignment is a discussion or a journal.

FOR STUDENTS [Understanding a writing prompt](#)

The student page that teaches how to read the prompt you write.

About this edition

The Language of College: A Reading, Writing & Communication Toolkit. Owensboro Community & Technical College.

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